

Sports **SHOOTING**

| By Sharda Ugra |

O kay, understand this. Elite shooters are lone wolves. They are tempestuous, temperamental and may act like lords but really, they are slaves of a sport that demands technical knowledge of a weapon's every nuance and the mental composure of a robot.

They obsess about keeping their hands dry, their grip relaxed and their heartbeat normal. The higher they go, the more the ankle weights of expectation drag them down, and fight them they must. As hard as they do competition and themselves. Recovering from the pressure of international events takes months. If victory and de-

feat swing between milliseconds and millimetres, so does their equilibrium.

Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra had lasik surgery of his eyes last year to improve his vision and chances. Double trap shooter Ronjon Sodhi will go to a recording studio to perfect the sound waves from his voice in order to trigger the automatic release of the trap machine at the absolute exact time. These are clearly the lone wolves of a kind that would send the other type sobbing to mother.

Yet, no other sport has won India back-to-back Olympic medals recently. No other sport has two Indian world champions. And yet, no other sport, it seems, treats its best like toothbrushes—disposable and replaceable.

At least that's what it looks like as

India's elite shooters, each with different dilemmas, are being sidelined and shafted by a common source of conflict. Their parent body, the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), is fast becoming a front runner for the title of India's single most heavy-handed sports federation. Given its recent record, it seems as if the NRAI is trying to knock KPS Gill's Indian Hockey Federation or the doped Indian Weightlifting Federation off the perch of the much-maligned. It has turned India's finest into targets.

All Bindra wants is to train in peace in Europe as he readies himself to defend his world championship title at Munich at the end of July. Suma Shirur, the only Indian woman to make it to an Olympic shooting

Way Off TARGET

Why the National Rifle Association of India is fast becoming a front runner for the most heavy-handed and mismanaged of Indian sports bodies

